between them, all too aware of my first-ball dismissal, as Goochy repeated, ‘Shit shot, shit shot,’ and Kevin replied with a few choice words of his own.

Damage was creeping from the field to the changing room. A team that once had a unique form of resilience was falling apart. We shied away from answering the toughest questions. Were we hiding from Mitchell Johnson? Why hadn’t we, as a leadership team, addressed his threat properly, instead of expecting people to play him as they wished?

Flower had been meeting KP on a weekly basis since 2012, to discuss potential problems as part of a proactive managerial strategy. It wasn’t as disruptive as has been claimed, but KP was high maintenance. He aired the possibility of flying home from Perth because of soreness in his knee but was talked down by Mushtaq Ahmed.

To be fair to him, he applied himself well in the final two Tests, without answering wider doubts about his motives. He was studiously engaged in public, helping less experienced players in the nets. Some saw ulterior motives, a politician creating a favourable impression. On balance, I preferred to give him the benefit of the doubt.

It was an extraordinarily febrile time, and mistakes were made under pressure. Joe Root had only one score over 26 in the first four Tests, but our batting was collectively poor. My 2010 series average of 127 certainly seemed an anomaly. Joe didn’t deserve to be singled out and dropped for Sydney; it proved a pivotal moment in his career. He used his disappointment and resentment positively, as motivation never to allow himself to be in that situation again.

Goochy, old school to the last, thought I should have administered more bollockings in team meetings. It wasn’t as simple as shouting. I had my head down, re-evaluating my approach, and realized I needed to take greater control. That meant easing my reliance on Flower, whose approach was criticized fiercely by KP in an intense players’-only meeting after defeat in Melbourne.

I’d depended on Andy too much and needed to drive the group in a different direction. As players, we needed to take ownership of our plight. That change of emphasis didn’t startle or intimidate me, because successful teams tend to have strong captains, assisted by coaches who drive behind-the-scenes improvement. My apprenticeship as a captain was complete.

The buck stopped with me. I tried to hold my head high and made a point of going out to see the Barmy Army in Sydney, but the loneliness of